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Until I got to the White house, I wrote all of my own speeches. But presidents make so many public appearances and have so many other demands on their schedule that I soon learned there wasn't enough time to write every speech and I would need help from the White House staff. Because I'd always taken pride in my speeches, this didn't sit well with me, but I didn't have much choice.

I continued to write my more important speeches, but much of the time I would sit down with White House speech writers and go over the points I wanted to make during an upcoming talk, and then they would present me with a draft to edit. I gave them copies of talks I'd made in the past so they would understand my style and technique, and I told them some of my rules for speaking: I prefer short sentences; don't use a word with two syllables if a one-syllable word will do; and if you can, use an example. An example is better than a sermon.

Sometimes, speech writers write things that seem very eloquent on paper, but sound convoluted or stilted when you say them to an audience. "Use simple language," I'd say. "Remember, there are people out there sitting and listening, they've got to be able to absorb what I'm saying."

When I was a sports announcer, I learned something about communicating with people I never forgot. I had a group of friends in Des Moines and we all happened to go to the same barber. My friends would sometimes sneak away from their offices or other jobs when I was broadcasting a game and they'd get together at the barbershop to listen to it; after a while, I began to picture these friends down at the shop when I was on the air and, knowing they were there,